Joe Lollo
BIS 372
Raissa DeSmet
24 November 2020

Voices From the Periphery
Creating a Canon From Marginalization and Displacement

As Bill Ashcroft explains in *The Empire Writes Back*, "post-colonial" literatures are often written in response to the English Canon's "inability" to express and detail the complexities of the colonized experience accurately and adequately (Ashcroft, 12). While English literature presents itself as "universal" through the Canon, in style, language, and genre, post-colonial literature comes from a need to revise the Canon's supposed universality to include a wider variety of voices. English colonialism in the Americas left no room for the "othered" voices: the oppressed, marginalized, and colonized people, often people of color, whose existence made colonialism in the first place. These literatures are meant to challenge the male-dominated English Canon that is grounded in the ideologies of colonialism and the Western metropolis. Even when the colonizers left the peripheries behind to return to Europe (dubbed "the Center" by Ashcroft), their strictly gendered legacy of colonialism persisted and changed the native cultures in its wake (Ashcroft, 11-12). By centering the experience of the "Other," post-colonial literatures create a Canon of their own that directly challenges the mainstream European narrative by providing representation to people marginalized by gender, ethnicity, class, or language.

In some cases, this legacy was not entirely unwelcome, especially in contrast with traditional societal expectations. Rhodesian-Zimbabwean author Tsitsi Dangarembga's 1988 novel *Nervous Conditions* has both of its female protagonists, Tambu and Nyasha, struggling to define and creating a new role for themselves as women in postcolonial Rhodesia. Their

exposure to European colonial ideals means that they cannot return to traditional Shona gender roles, but they cannot fully escape their Shona roots either. Tambu and Nyasha find themselves challenging and at odds with their family patriarch, Babamakuru, who is increasingly dissatisfied when the girls do not simultaneously mold themselves to modern and traditional gender roles.

Tambu excitedly attempts to leave her Shona heritage behind by pursuing a modern, English education at the school where Babamakuru is the headmaster. Her attempts to decolonize herself from the strict Shona expectations for females is downcast by the fact that she only attends because her older brother was killed in the midst of his studies. When Tambu passively states at the beginning of the novel, "The events that put me in a position to write this account" (Dangarembga 1), she is acknowledging that any effort on her part was overridden by previous events. Babamakuru ultimately proves to be even more controlling of his daughter and niece's futures than Tambu imagined from her Shona village: he simultaneously expects the girls to exceed in school, but also be passive and domestic. These harsh expectations are a result of Babamakuru mimicking European colonialism and its own gendered expectations of puritanism, while steadfastly holding tight to traditional Shona culture as well (DeSmet, class discussion). While Tambu and Nyasha suffer greatly and do not always succeed in standing up to Babamakuru, the very fact that they try to carve out unique and previously undefined roles for themselves in a postcolonial world, challenges European (and Shona) narratives filled with passive and silenced women who yield to male authority figures.

Tambu submits so fully to Babamakuru not only because he is the patriarch, but also because of his own educational success and achievements. Babamakuru rises higher than any of Tambu's family members ever previously dreamed. Tambu clearly states, "How can I describe the sensations that swamped me...on the day I left my home? ….When I stepped into

Babamakuru's car I was a peasant" (Dangarembga, 58). Tambu commits herself to this idealized version of higher-class life, imagining herself as leaving an entirely different person behind and awaiting a new person at her school. She is never fully able to leave her Shona self behind though, and she vacillates between these two positions, never able to secure an absolute position on one or the other side of the divide. Such vacillation between her past and future underscores the contradictory sides of identity.

Tambu is only able to eventually discredit colonial views of classism by engaging in the same mimicry as Babamakuru, and realizing the emptiness and loneliness behind it. The adult narrator Tambu recognizes the humanity in the native villagers and family members that young Tambu does not and is eager to leave behind. Tambu's self-realization and self-discrediting of colonialism comes full circle when she sees the hopelessness of existing within its structures but originating from its peripheries. She eventually realizes that while she might be able to rise above her class, she will never fully escape it. Tambu challenges English colonialism the way post-colonial writers challenge the English canon, both grounded in the expansion of th eWestern metropolis.

Adrienne Rich describes post-coloniality as "the act of looking back, seeing with fresh eyes, and entering the world from a new, yet critical direction," with authors from this genre often utilizing the literary technique of re-visioning, "an act of survival" that comes with re-inventing the plot of other pieces (Rich, 114-115). Jean Rhys' 1967 novel *Wide Sargasso Sea* is an example of how post-colonial writers can re-vision Canonical texts, as the novel acts as a prequel to Charlotte Bronte's *Jane Eyre*. Through its protagonist, Antoinette, being a revision of Bertha Mason from *Jane Eyre*, readers can see the necessity of this technique when a character is mis-represented as a result of a history that must be corrected. Antoinette's perspective is a

second look at Bertha's descent into madness as a long-lasting effect of the process of colonization. Rhys addresses this by contrasting the cultures of England and Jamaica as well as their gender roles, exploring female submission as an outcome of oppression much like Dangarembga did (Rich, 115). Rhys' re-vision of Bronte featured a new focus on the alienated experience of a woman of color, previously only seen through the white gaze of Jane and Mr. Rochester, the latter being *Wide Sargasso Sea*'s antagonist – and rendered as voiceless. This was even hinted at in the novel, as Antoinette tells readers "there is always the other side – always" before she is brought to Rochester's home (Rhys, 81).

Being a woman of color with a white father, Antoinette has an inability to feel a sense of belonging to any specific race, yet she is also categorized by others into distinct racial identities, which distances her from both Jamaican and English culture. She often finds herself wondering and seeking a place to belong, making her vulnerable to Mr. Rochester's views from his initial kindness and affection. Despite this, Antionette's very existence is a representation of power, as she is a woman of color who was educated by nuns and has her own version of language that isn't considered incorrect, which Rochester – standing in for English colonialism as a whole – is quickly able to squash.

Antoinette's status as a mixed-race woman of color, and Mr. Rochester's surprising initial attraction to her, ultimately represent everything that is revolutionary and subversive about the Third World. Despite peripheries searching for validation from the Center, Rochester's inability to understand Antoinette's feelings and passions is an interpretation of England's failure to comprehend the "negro world," as he calls it, during the Colonial Era, leading to him taking his "plunder" back to England and "civilize" her (Rhys, 27). European colonialism was what

created the racism ingrained into Creole culture (even against mulattos like Antoinette), and Rhys has Rochester confirm this belief of "power" through his subjugation of Antoinette's color.

Antoinette does not submit quietly to Rochester and colonialism, however, and it is only through her deeply impassioned need for love and validation that she gives away the power she has to Rochester. However, Rochester's racist views keeps him from truly "loving" Antoinette and treating her with basic decency, even when he has the chance to end her suffering and allow her to remain in Jamaica. His thirst for power, rooted in the Colonial era's indoctrination, keeps him from ever being able to truly connect with Antoinette on a human level because she is "nothing more than a mulatto" (Rhys, 53). Rochester explicitly refers to Antoinette as "alien" to English nature and culture, an alarming mix of sexuality and savagery, of "unnatural propensities and alien primitivism" (Rhys, 53-54). Rochester resents Antoinette not solely for her color, but because she defies colonialism and attempts to define her own life in spite of her color, and his views (DeSmet, class discussion).

Antoinette and her Creole culture are subversive to Rochester and colonialism because of their defiant use of "improper" English, even in his midst. The voices of Creole people come to life in Wide Sargasso Sea in a way that is not experienced in many other novels: grammar, punctuation, sentence structure and use of dialect/accents all uniquely give representation to periphery voices that are never heard in European literatures. The contrast between Rochester's "proper" and refined English and the English of the Creole culture highlight the vast distance and tension between the two cultures. Rochester refuses to hide his disdain for the "Black" English of Antoinette's Indigenous housekeeper Christophine, telling Antoinette that "her coffee is delicious, but that language of hers is horrible" (Rhys, 32). Despite Christophine having spoken to him correctly and with a firm grasp of the English language, because her word choice and

grammar are not considered proper, her whole effort is deemed 'incorrect' by Rochester. Christophine speaking to him without deferring to proper English subverts the colonial idea of propriety and the place of the periphery within white society.

Nervous Conditions and *Wide Sargasso Sea* offer readers with a wealth of evidence into how post-colonial literature has the power to both give autonomy to writers and characters of color and revise dominant historical narratives. Post-colonial texts directly interact with the English Canon to dismantle its Westernized narrative by expressing the experiences of those oppressed and displaced by colonialism and conveying the existence of rich cultural heritages older and more extensive than that of Europe. They bridge the gap in history that was left by the Canon, serving as an insight of a fuller colonized experience. These inclusions serve to create a more complete literary canon that voices the breadth of sufferings and successes of people attempting to create their identity in a post-colonial world.

Works Cited

Ashcroft, Bill. *The Empire Writes Back: The Theory & Practice of Post-Colonial Literature*. London: Routledge, 2002.

Dangarembga, Tsitsi. *Nervous Conditions*. London: The Women's Press, 1988.

DeSmet, Raissa. Class discussions on *The Empire Writes Back*, *Wide Sargasso Sea*, and *Nervous Conditions*. BIS 372, Post-Colonial Literatures. University of Washington Bothell, October – November 2020.

Rhys, Jean. *Wide Sargasso Sea* (1967). Oxford: Oxford World's Classics, 2019.

Rich, Adrienne. "When We Dead Awaken: Re-Writing and Re-Visioning History." *College English* 34.1 (Oct. 1972): 113-126.